NSW BIODIVERSITY CREDIT OPPORTUNITY MAP · BRIEFING NOTE

Briefing note: Where to look for new biodiversity credit supply

Topic	Remaining native vegetation for six under-supplied ecosystem credit types, NSW
Prepared by	Likitha Vankadoth (independent portfolio analysis, not an official NSW Government document)
Date	11 October 2026
Purpose	To identify IBRA subregions worth investigating for new Biodiversity Stewardship Agreements

Recommendations

1. **Note** the five subregions below as *areas for further investigation* for new credit supply: Inland Slopes, Macleay Hastings, Hill End, Orange and Karuah Manning.
2. **Prioritise** Southwest Ranges White Box Woodland (PCT 3406) around **Hill End and Orange**. It is 89% cleared, has no credits available, and only 0.6% of what remains is protected.
3. **Field-validate** any shortlisted area before engaging landholders. The vegetation map is regional scale, and its accuracy at vegetation-type level is moderate.
4. **Ask DCCEEW to publish** a lookup between retired and current vegetation types (PCTs), so that demand for retired types can be matched to supply.

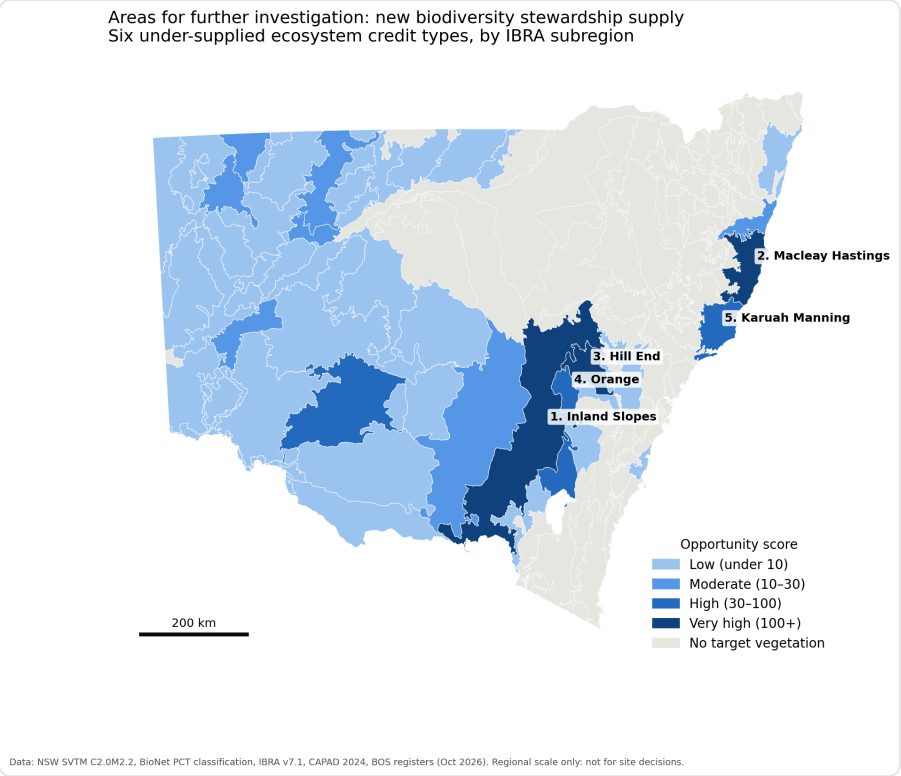
Background

- The Biodiversity Offsets Scheme needs credits for the **same vegetation type** that a development clears (like-for-like).
- An earlier analysis of the BOS registers (Project 1, October 2026) found that 43 credit types have **zero credits available** but are still being retired by developers. This matches the NSW Audit Office (2022) and IPART (2026), which report widespread unmet demand.
- New supply depends on landholders with the **right remnant vegetation** entering stewardship agreements. This note shows where that vegetation remains.

Key findings

Credit type (PCT)	Remaining	Protected	% cleared	Retired/yr	Main subregions
309 Black Cypress Pine – Red Stringybark	7,424 ha	39%	15%	507	Inland Slopes (99%)
290 Red Stringybark – Red Box	42,852 ha	23%	67%	289	Inland Slopes (almost all)
3406 Southwest Ranges White Box	14,988 ha	**0.6%**	**89%**	127	Hill End, Orange (83%)
4047 Northern Swamp Mahogany	4,746 ha	45%	33%	153	Macleay Hastings, Karuah Manning (90%)
24 Canegrass swamp	790,654 ha	10%	20%	155	Bulloo, Lachlan, Paroo Overflow

- **Supply is geographically concentrated.** The two most-demanded types (309 and 290) survive almost only in **Inland Slopes**, so a few landholders there could ease the shortage.
- **The ranking is robust.** The same top five subregions appear under four different weightings, including equal weights.
- **Biodiversity value is high.** Each top subregion has 66–211 threatened species recorded in BioNet. These counts are context only: they reflect survey effort.



Considerations and limitations

- **Mapping accuracy.**
  - Reported vegetation-type accuracy is 57–76% by region (SVTM technical notes, 2022).
  - A Hunter field check found only 17% of labels correct (Hunter, 2016).
  - The map is not site scale.
- **Reclassified types.** PCT 1600 was retired in 2022, and PCT 1604 maps to only 5 ha. Their demand cannot be traced on the current map.
- **% cleared.** BioNet's official figures were used. The pre-clearing map gave very different results (for example, 6% cleared vs 67% for PCT 290).
- **Remnant is not supply.**
  - Tenure, condition and landholder interest are unknown.
  - Each site still needs a full Biodiversity Assessment Method survey.
- **Demand is a lower bound.** It is based on retirements, which miss unmet obligations.
- **Sensitive species.** Only counts per subregion are reported, with no locations, in line with the BioNet Sensitive Species Data Policy.

Next steps

- Share the ranked list with the Biodiversity Conservation Trust for comment.
- Overlay cadastre and tenure for the top five subregions.
- Plan field validation for PCT 3406 around Hill End and Orange.

Sources: DCCEEW SVTM C2.0M2.2; BioNet Vegetation Classification and Atlas; IBRA v7.1; CAPAD 2024; BOS public registers (Oct 2026); Audit Office of NSW (2022); IPART (2026); Hunter (2016) Ecological Management & Restoration 17(1).